

NextTrack Music Recommendation System

Participant Information Sheet

Project Title

NextTrack: A Diversity- and Preference-Aware Music Recommendation System

Researcher

Kurt Charles
CM3070 Computer Science Final Project
University of London
Email: kurtcharles07@gmail.com

Invitation

You are invited to take part in a user evaluation of **NextTrack**, a music recommendation prototype developed as part of my Computer Science final project at the University of London.

Before deciding whether to participate, please read the information below carefully. It explains the purpose of the evaluation, what you will be asked to do, what information will be collected, and how your responses will be used.

Participation is entirely voluntary.

What is NextTrack?

NextTrack is a prototype music recommendation system designed to investigate how music recommendations can balance **contextual relevance, diversity, exploration, and explicit user preferences**.

The system generates recommendations based on a recent listening context consisting of three tracks. For this evaluation, you will use a controlled **Study Mode** in which you will compare two recommendation sets generated from the same recent listening context. The internal settings used to generate the two sets will not be shown to you during the evaluation so that they do not influence your judgement.

What is the purpose of this evaluation?

The purpose of this evaluation is to assess how users perceive recommendation sets produced by NextTrack under different recommendation conditions.

In particular, the study will examine participants' perceptions of:

- relevance to the recent listening context;
- diversity or variety;
- usefulness for discovering music;
- overall satisfaction; and
- preference between alternative recommendation sets.

The results will be considered alongside the project's technical evaluation to assess whether the recommendation approach produces meaningful differences from a user's perspective.

What will I be asked to do?

If you agree to participate, you will:

1. receive a unique participant code;
2. use the NextTrack **Study Mode** interface;
3. use the same participant code throughout the evaluation;
4. evaluate three listening contexts:
 - Rock;
 - Hip-Hop; and
 - Country;
5. review three recent listening tracks for each context;
6. generate two recommendation sets labelled **Recommendation Set A** and **Recommendation Set B**;
7. review both recommendation sets;
8. briefly listen to at least **three tracks from Set A and three tracks from Set B** using the provided Spotify links before rating the sets;
9. rate each recommendation set for:
 - relevance;
 - diversity;
 - usefulness for music discovery; and
 - overall satisfaction;
10. indicate which recommendation set you would prefer to receive; and
11. complete a short set of questions about your overall experience with the system.

You do not need to listen to each recommended track in full. Brief listening is sufficient to help you form a judgement.

The settings used to generate Recommendation Set A and Recommendation Set B will intentionally not be shown during the evaluation. This is intended to reduce bias and allow you to judge the recommendations based on your own experience. There are no correct or incorrect responses.

How long will participation take?

The evaluation is expected to take approximately **10–15 minutes**.

The exact time may vary depending on how long you choose to spend reviewing or listening to the recommended tracks.

Do I have to participate?

No.

Participation is entirely voluntary. You may choose not to participate, and you may stop the evaluation at any time before submitting your responses without giving a reason.

Choosing not to participate, or deciding to stop participating, will not result in any disadvantage or penalty.

What information will be collected?

The questionnaire will collect:

- your assigned participant code;
- general information about your use of music streaming services;
- general information about your use of automatically generated music recommendations;
- the importance of discovering new music to you;
- ratings of Recommendation Set A and Recommendation Set B;
- your preferred recommendation set;
- optional written comments explaining your preferences; and
- ratings and comments about your overall experience with NextTrack.

The evaluation does **not require your name**.

The questionnaire is intended to use participant codes rather than personally identifying information.

The questionnaire is configured not to automatically collect your name or email address.

How will my responses be used?

Responses will be used to:

- evaluate the usability and perceived effectiveness of the NextTrack prototype;
- compare users' perceptions of different recommendation conditions;
- compare subjective user feedback with the project's technical evaluation results;
- support the evaluation of the NextTrack Computer Science final project; and
- contribute to aggregated findings presented in the final project report.

Results will be reported in summary or pseudonymised form and will not intentionally identify individual participants.

Optional written comments may be quoted in the final project report where relevant, but they will not be associated with your name.

How will my data be handled?

Questionnaire responses will be associated with a participant code rather than your name.

If any separate record is required to manage participant-code allocation, it will be kept separately from the questionnaire response data.

The collected data will be used only for the purposes described in this study and will be handled in accordance with applicable University of London research, ethical, and data-protection requirements. After the required retention period, the data will be securely deleted where appropriate.

Can I withdraw my responses?

You may stop participating at any point before submitting the questionnaire.

Use the statement below that matches the withdrawal procedure approved for your project.

If submitted responses can be removed using the participant code

After submission, you may request withdrawal of your responses by providing your participant code until: Monday, September 14, 2026.

After this date, the results may have been combined with other responses for analysis, and it may no longer be possible to remove an individual response.

Because responses cannot be linked back to you after submission, it may not be possible to identify and withdraw an individual response once it has been submitted.

Are there any risks?

Possible inconveniences include:

- the time required to complete the evaluation;
- unfamiliarity with some of the recommended music;
- minor frustration if a Spotify link or prototype feature does not work as expected; and
- mild fatigue from comparing several recommendation sets.

You may stop participating at any time before submission.

Are there any benefits?

There is no guaranteed personal benefit from participating.

However, you may find the process of exploring and comparing music recommendations interesting.

Your responses will contribute to the evaluation of NextTrack and help determine whether its approach to balancing relevant and exploratory recommendations provides a useful user experience.

Use of Spotify

NextTrack provides links to Spotify so that participants can briefly listen to tracks when evaluating recommendation sets.

Using these links is part of the recommended evaluation procedure, but you are not expected to listen to any track in full.

Spotify is an external service and is not operated by NextTrack or the University of London. If you open a Spotify link, your use of Spotify is subject to Spotify's own terms, privacy practices, regional availability, and account settings.

A Spotify account is not required to complete questionnaire responses based on the track and artist information displayed by NextTrack.

Confidentiality

Your responses will be treated confidentially within the limits of the study.

The project report will present results in aggregated or pseudonymised form.

The report will not intentionally identify individual participants.

Where optional written comments are quoted, they will be presented without your name or other identifying information.

Questions or concerns

If you have any questions about the evaluation or the NextTrack project, please contact:

Kurt Charles

Email: kurtcharles07@gmail.com

What happens next?

If you have read and understood this Participant Information Sheet and would like to take part, please continue to the consent section of the questionnaire.

You should only proceed with the NextTrack evaluation after providing your consent.

You will then be given or asked to enter your participant code and will use the same code throughout all three listening contexts.